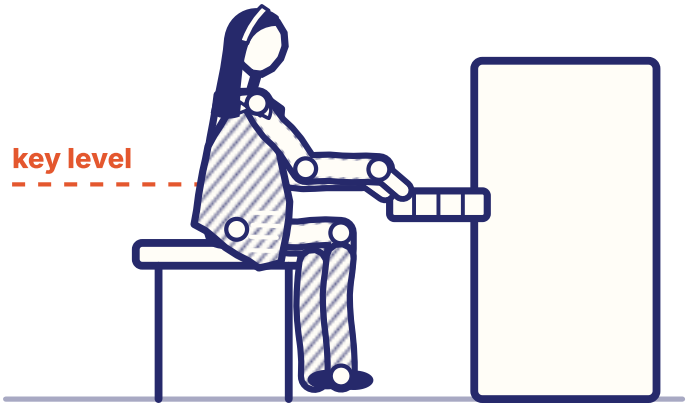
BEFORE YOU PLAY

Posture and hand shape

How you sit and how you hold your hands decide how easy everything else will be. Set them up before the first note, check them every time you sit down, and they soon look after themselves.

THE SECRET

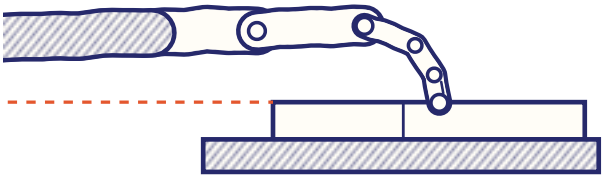
Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.



1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet

A round hand



knuckles up like a bridge, the wrist level, the sound from the **fingertip**

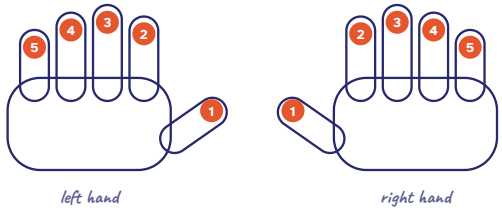


the shape a hand makes resting on a ball

PART OF THE HAND	WHAT IT DOES
fingertips	play the keys, just behind the nail (keep nails short)
knuckles	stay up, like a bridge: they never sink in
thumb	plays on the side of its tip, relaxed, not stretched out
wrist	level with the hand, loose, never resting on the wood

BEFORE YOU PLAY · CONTINUED

Finger numbers



Every finger has a number, **the same in both hands**: the thumb is **1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**. Music often prints these numbers above or below the notes.

More on choosing fingers: Fingering p. 163.

Six warm-ups



1 · Rag doll

Flop forward, arms hanging heavy. Shake them loose. Float the hands up onto the keys.



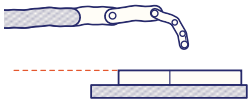
2 · Elbow wings

Elbows free, not stuck to your body. Float them out like wings, then back.



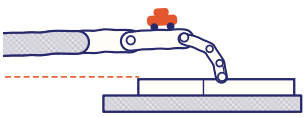
3 · Arm glide

Skate the whole arm along the keys. The round hand rides to the next group of keys.



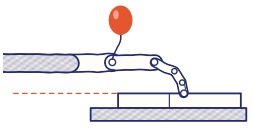
4 · Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 · Knuckle bridge

Your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3.

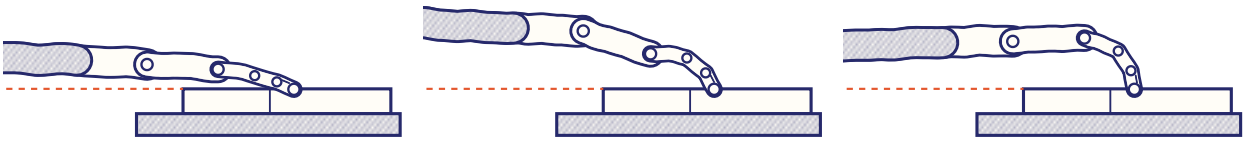


6 · Wrist balloon

As the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

EXAMPLE 1

Which hand is round?



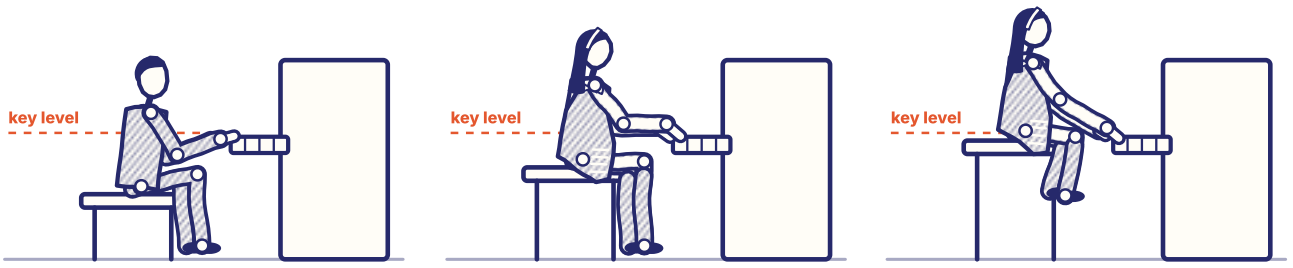
1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

BEFORE YOU PLAY · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Is the stool right?



A B C

1. **Follow the forearm** from the elbow to the keys.
2. **Uphill or downhill?** Then the stool is too low or too high.
3. **Which one** is level?

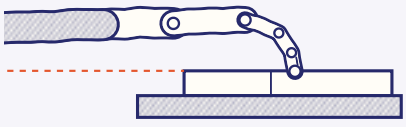
B: the forearm is level. In A the stool is too low (raise it, or add a cushion); in C it is too high.

HOW TO

The 30-second check, every time you sit down

1. **Stool:** forearms level with the keys, opposite Middle C.
2. **Body:** front half of the stool, feet flat, back tall.
3. **Shoulders:** lift them, then let them drop.
4. **Hands:** a soft ball under each palm, knuckles up.
5. **Breathe out**, then play.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

THINK OF IT A good posture is like a well-tuned bicycle: you stop noticing it, and every ride gets easier.

TRAP

- × Wrists that sink below the keys, or rest on the wood: keep them level and loose.
- × Shoulders creeping up to the ears: let them drop between pieces.
- × Flat fingers, or a knuckle that caves in: stand on the fingertips.
- × Sitting too close, elbows squashed against your body: move the stool back a little.

SEE ALSO
Fingering p. 163 · Practising well p. 165

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Posture & Hand Shape